MyDFIR | SOC Email Investigation Report

CNN "5 Things PM" Newsletter • Likely Benign

Prepared by Rona Playda | MyDFIR SOC Simulator | 6 November 2026

Findings

Time	**6 Nov 2026, 21:00:12–21:00:17 UTC (header creation to delivery)**
Recipient	zbalrog@mapletaxsolutions.ca
Sender	CNN's 5 Things PM <5things@email.cnn.com>
Subject	White House shake-up, help for caregivers, Cybertruck's demise
Sending IP	137.22.248.132
Sending hostname	enlz2erc.email.cnn.com
Domains reviewed	email.cnn.com; li.cnn.com
Network Message ID	03fd658c-869d-49fd-f341-08df3c48f3dd
Malware / hash	None identified; no attachments reported
Disposition	LIKELY BENIGN — No malicious activity identified in available evidence

An inbound CNN-branded newsletter was delivered to the recipient's inbox. SPF, DKIM, DMARC and composite authentication passed; Microsoft classified it as not spam (SCL 1). No attachments or Defender threat classification were observed. IP and domain reputation checks showed no VirusTotal malicious detections; AbuseIPDB recorded two email-spam complaints from one reporter. The email body was unavailable due to simulator permissions.

Investigation Objective

The purpose of this investigation was to determine whether the CNN-branded email contained indicators of phishing or other malicious activity. Using Microsoft Defender XDR, I reviewed email authentication, delivery status, message headers, sender IP reputation, URLs, and available click telemetry. Based on the evidence collected, I classified the email as Likely Benign. However, I could not fully verify the email content because message preview access was restricted.

Investigation

The analyst reviewed Microsoft Defender Explorer, message headers, Microsoft 365 filtering, VirusTotal, AbuseIPDB, and Advanced Hunting. The observations below distinguish recorded evidence from conclusions that cannot be verified in the simulator.

WHO / WHAT / WHEN / WHERE / WHY / HOW

WHO	**Sender shown as CNN's 5 Things PM; recipient zbalrog@mapletaxsolutions.ca. Sender-domain authentication passed.**
WHAT	An inbound newsletter with no attachments was delivered. No confirmed malicious indicators were identified.
WHEN	6 Nov 2026, approximately 21:00 UTC; headers show about five seconds between message creation and final receipt.
WHERE	Sender IP 137.22.248.132, hostname enlz2erc.email.cnn.com, routed through Microsoft 365 to the recipient inbox.
WHY	Apparent news/promotional newsletter; sender intent and full message content cannot be independently verified without body access.

HOW	Email was transmitted via third-party sending infrastructure and Microsoft Exchange Online Protection; SPF, DKIM and DMARC passed.

1. Sender authentication and mail routing

Header analysis recorded spf=pass, dkim=pass, dmarc=pass, and compauth=pass. SPF authorized 137.22.248.132 for email.cnn.com; DKIM signed with d=email.cnn.com. The Received chain showed SparkPost-related infrastructure, enlz2erc.email.cnn.com and Microsoft 365 transport. Authentication makes straightforward domain spoofing less likely, but does not prove message content is safe.

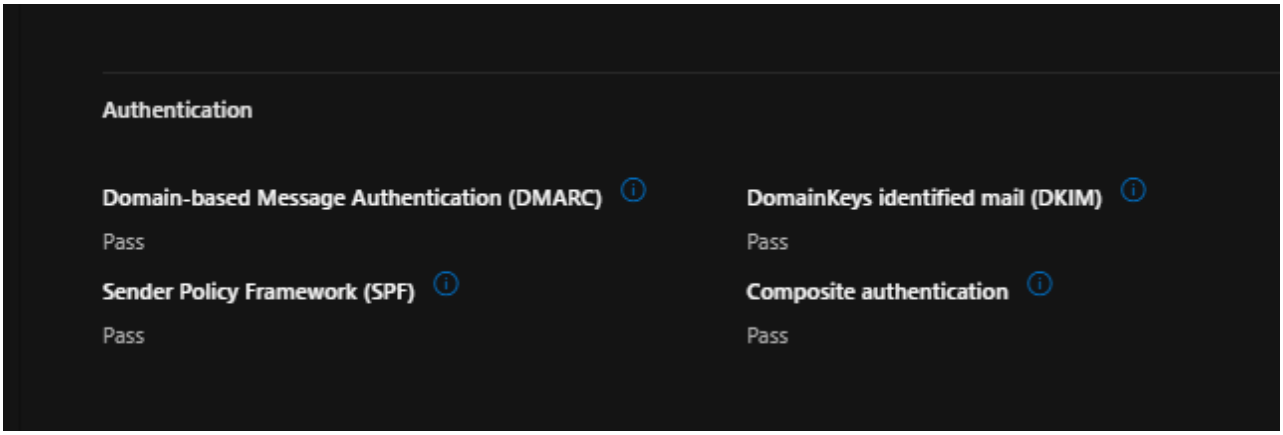


Figure 1. Defender Explorer: SPF, DKIM, DMARC and composite authentication passed.

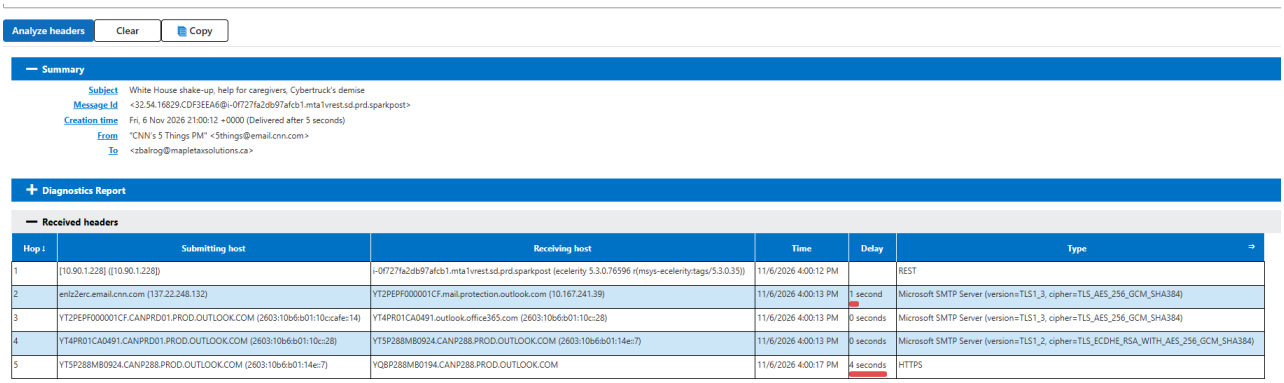


Figure 2. Message header analyzer: sender, recipient and Received routing hops.

2. Microsoft antispam filtering

Microsoft assigned Spam Confidence Level (SCL) 1 and verdict SFV:NSPM (not spam), with CAT:NONE. Bulk Complaint Level (BCL) was 2 and the bulk category was Promotions. Mailing-list unsubscribe headers were present. These are consistent with bulk newsletter delivery but are not guarantees of safety.



Figure 3. Forefront antispam analysis: sending IP, SCL 1 and NSPM verdict.

3. Domain and sending-IP reputation

VirusTotal displayed 0/92 malicious vendor detections for li.cnn.com and 0/92 for the sending IP 137.22.248.132. Many IP vendors were unrated; the displayed IP analysis was approximately nine months old. AbuseIPDB showed a 3% abuse confidence score, two reports from one reporter, and Email Spam as the report category. The IP hostname matched the mail headers and was associated with Braze, Inc. / AS23528 on AbuseIPDB. Although AbuseIPDB identified a small number of spam reports, VirusTotal showed no malicious detections for the sending IP. Based on the available evidence, there was insufficient justification to classify the sender IP as malicious or recommend blocking it.

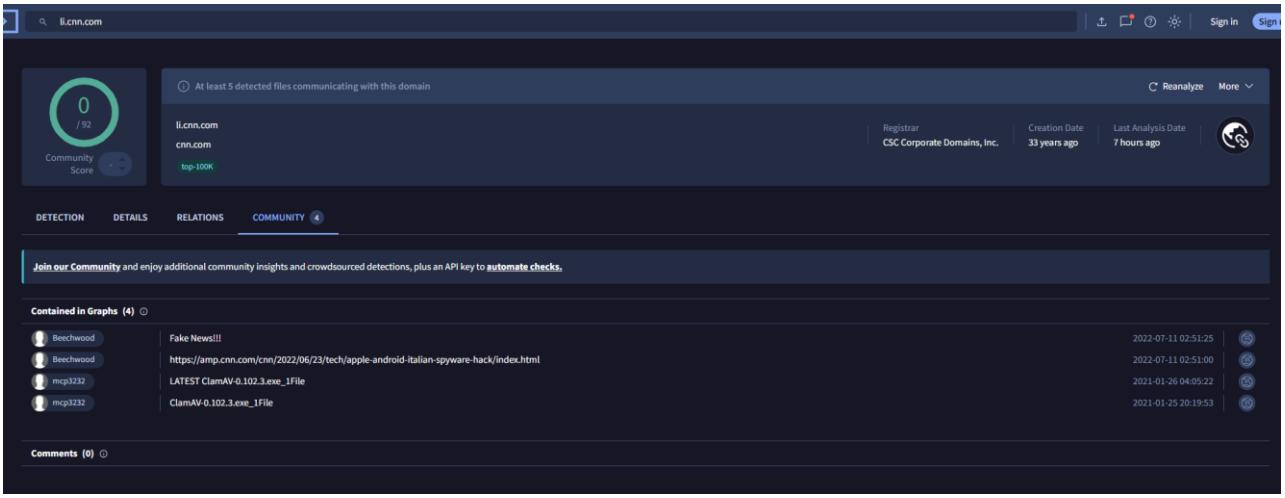


Figure 4. VirusTotal: li.cnn.com domain reputation (0/92 malicious detections).

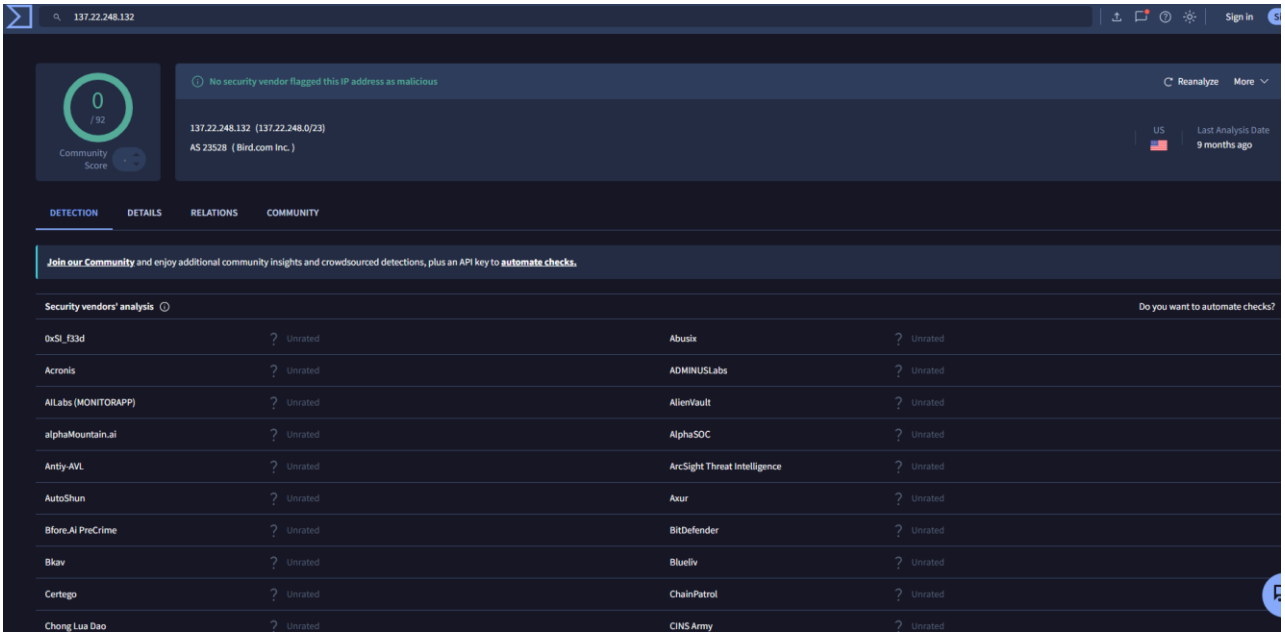


Figure 5. VirusTotal: sending IP 137.22.248.132 (0/92 malicious detections).

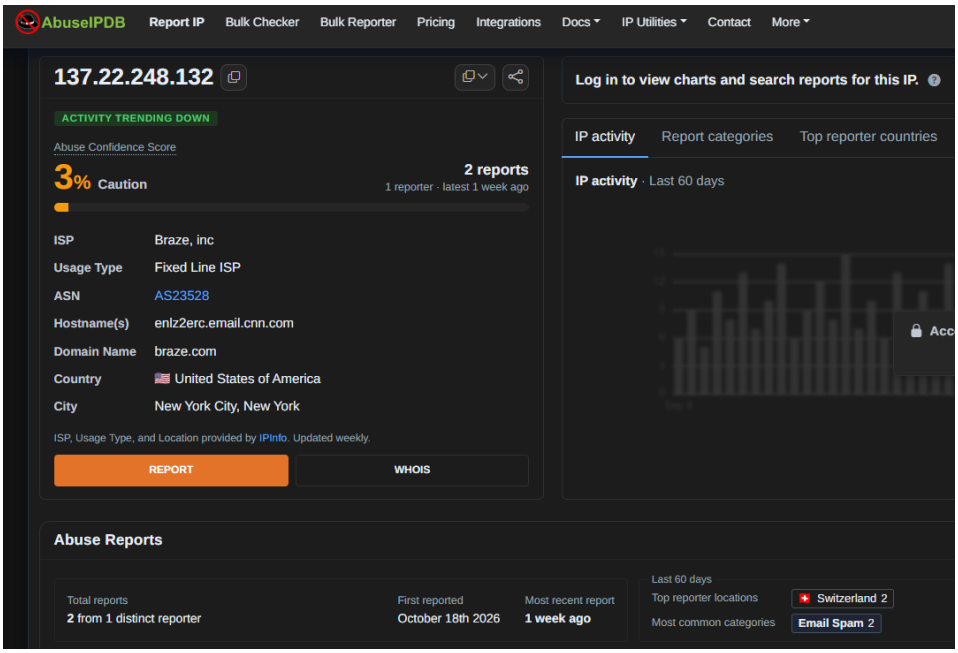


Figure 6. AbuseIPDB: 3% confidence, two email-spam reports, sender hostname and geolocation.

4. Attachments and URL interaction

Defender Explorer showed no attachments. A message-specific Advanced Hunting search of UrlClickEvents returned zero matching records in the queried window. This means no click events were observed in the available telemetry; it does not prove the recipient never clicked a link.

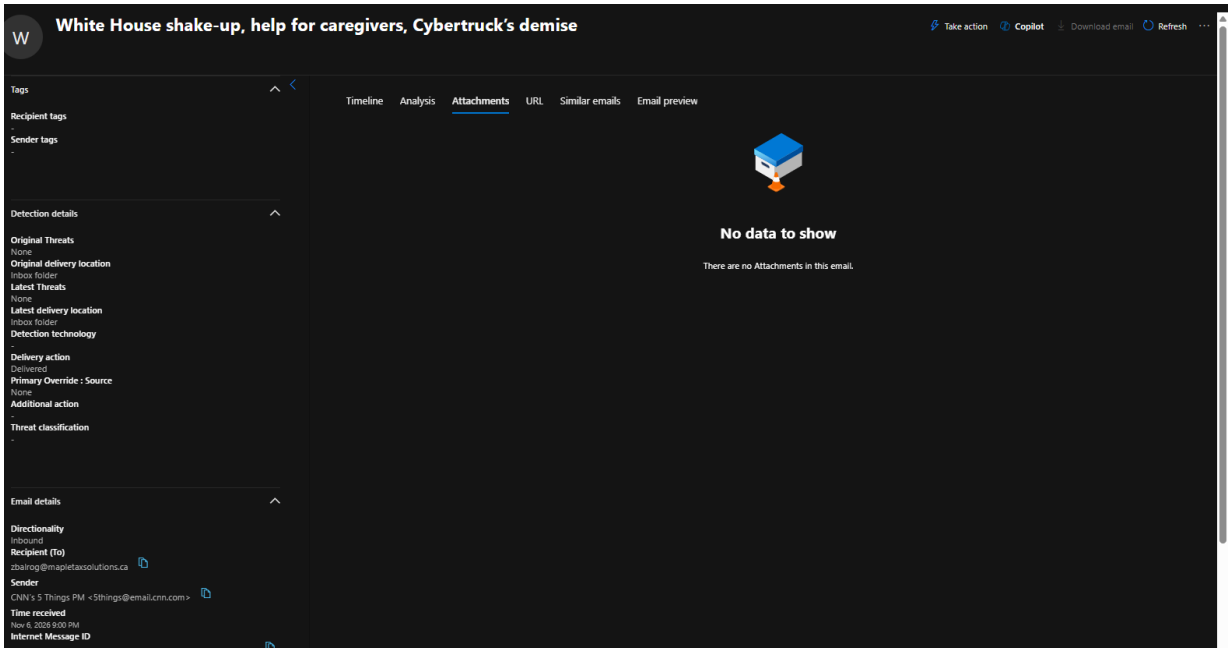


Figure 7. Defender Explorer: no attachments for this email.

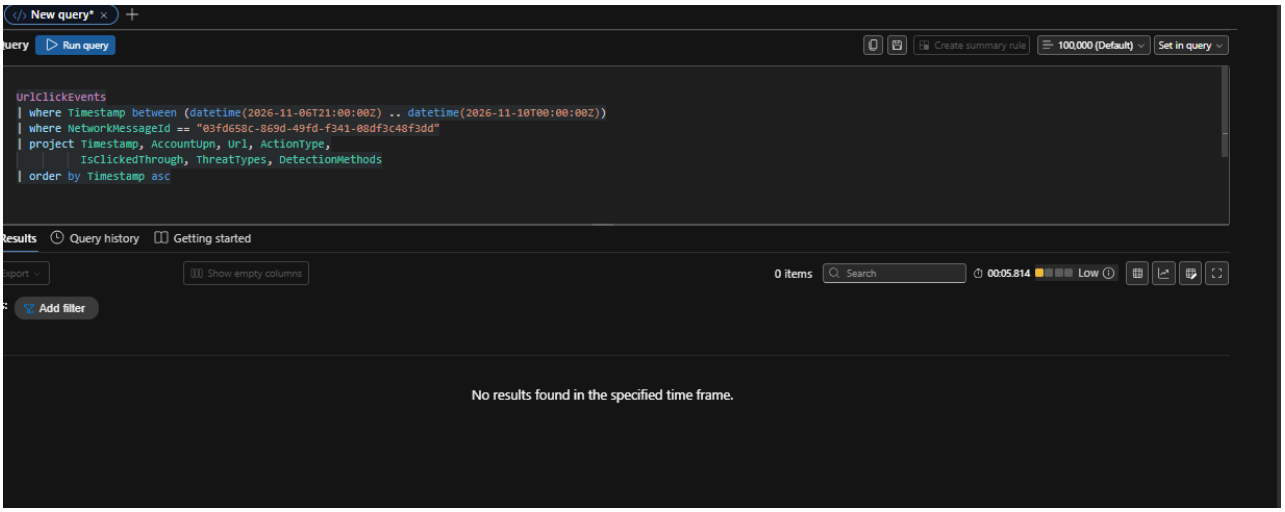


Figure 8. Advanced Hunting UrlClickEvents: no matching records for the message ID.

5. Newsletter impression URL: sandbox and reputation review

The email contained a li.cnn.com/imp URL. A VirusTotal URL analysis performed on 7 November 2026 returned 0/93 security-vendor detections. The analyzed request returned HTTP 200 with image/jpeg content, involved multiple redirects and external resources, and listed an advertising-related destination at c.licasd.com. The URL pattern and image response are consistent with newsletter impression tracking, but this purpose is inferred rather than independently confirmed. The sandbox request does not establish that the recipient clicked or loaded the URL. No malicious behavior was confirmed by this analysis.

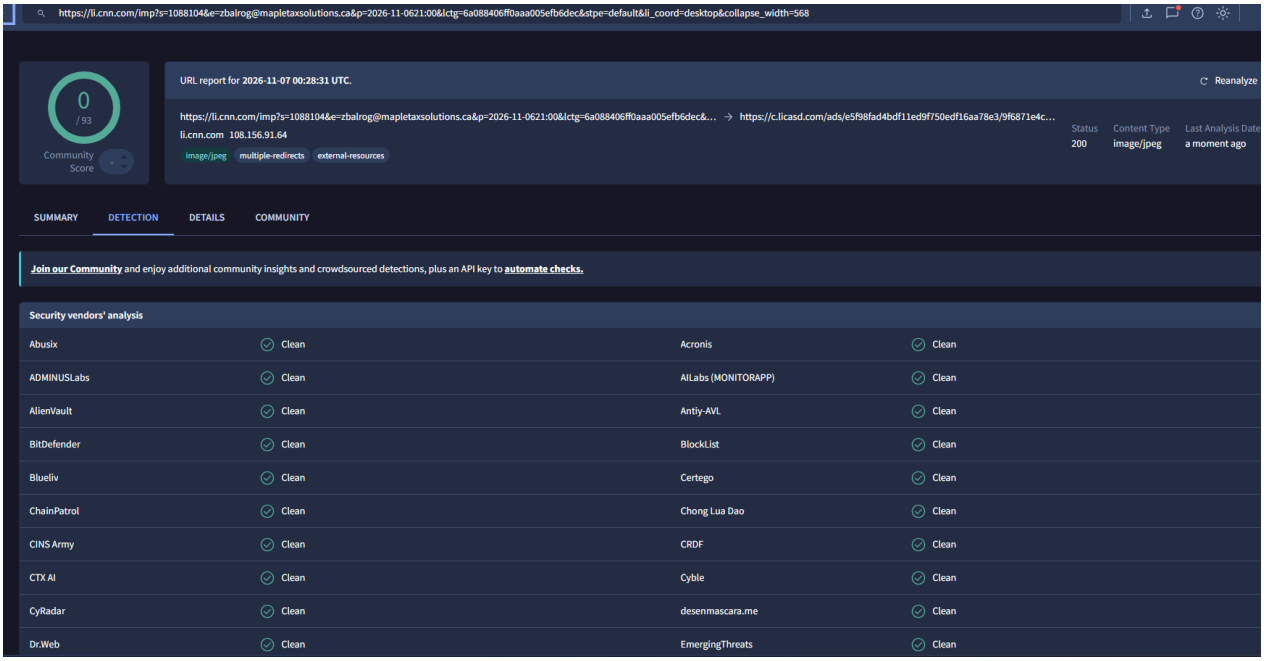


Figure 9. VirusTotal analysis of li.cnn.com/imp: 0/93 detections, HTTP 200, JPEG content, and redirect to c.licasd.com.

6. Delivery confirmation and visibility limitation

An EmailEvents query filtered on the exact Network Message ID returned one matching record, showing DeliveryAction=Delivered and DeliveryLocation=Inbox/folder. Threat classification fields were empty. Email Preview displayed a permission error, preventing inspection of message text, displayed links, and social-engineering cues.

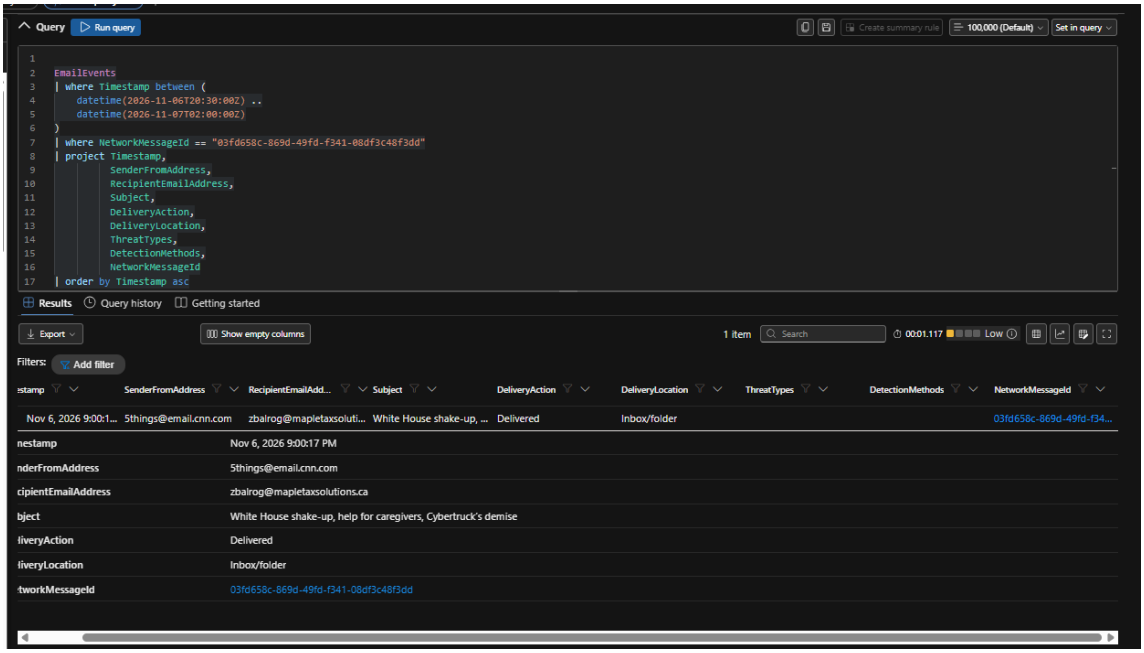


Figure 10. Advanced Hunting EmailEvents: one matching delivered email record.

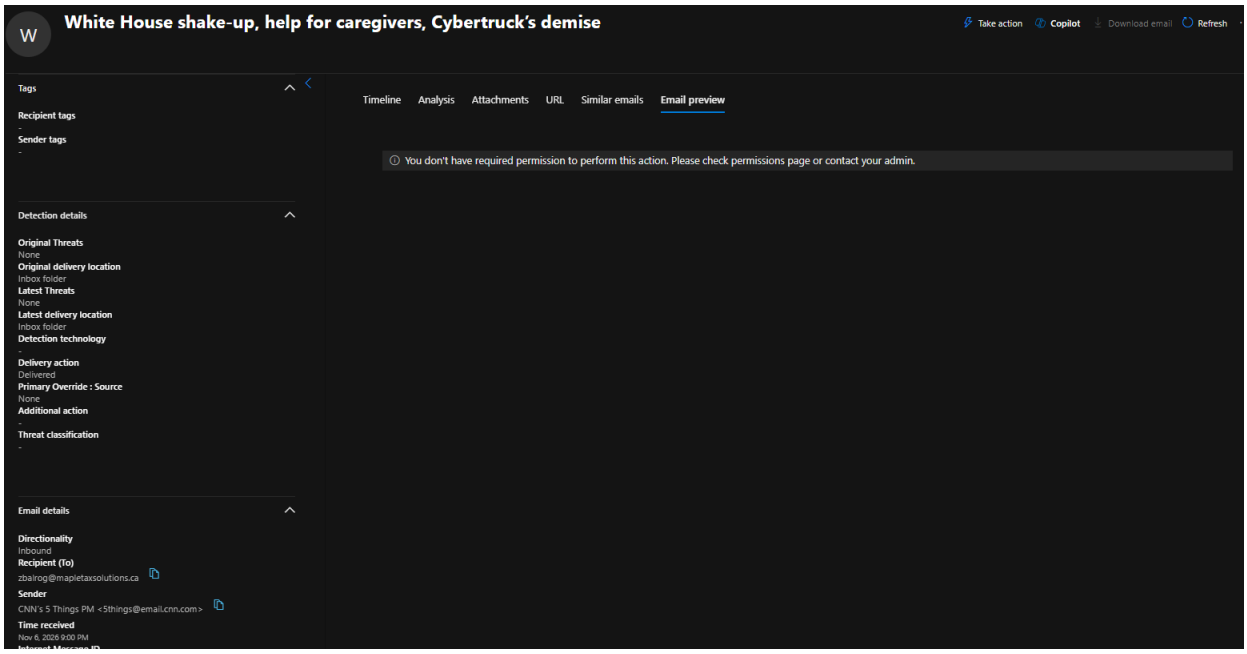


Figure 11. Email Preview: simulator permission restriction documented.

Recommendations

1) Close this training case as Likely Benign, preserving the Network Message ID, header results, reputation findings and supporting screenshots. Do not describe the email as definitively safe.

2) No device isolation, account revocation, sender-IP block, or message quarantine is warranted from the current evidence. The two AbuseIPDB reports concern email spam and do not establish a security incident.

3) If the recipient reports suspicious content or credential entry, request an authorized message-body review and investigate exact URLs, Safe Links clicks, endpoint activity, and Entra ID sign-ins before determining containment or escalation.

Final Assessment

LIKELY BENIGN — No malicious activity was identified in the available evidence. The message passed authentication checks, was delivered to the inbox, and showed no confirmed malicious URL or attachment activity. This verdict is limited by restricted message-body access, potentially incomplete click telemetry, and the age or coverage of reputation results. The sandbox URL analysis did not establish recipient interaction.

Lessons Learned

This MyDFIR SOC Simulator investigation strengthened my ability to correlate Microsoft Defender XDR email records, message headers, Advanced Hunting results, and external threat-intelligence findings. I practiced distinguishing authentication and reputation signals from proof of safety, documenting telemetry limitations, and making proportionate recommendations without taking unsupported containment actions.